

Technology News



Linux 2.6.28 is out with ext4 flagged

"It doesn't really matter what day it is, or what holiday (if any) you're celebrating, because even if you sit at home, alone in your dank basement, without any holidays or friends, I bring you tidings of great cheer: you can now download Linux-2.6.28, and compile it to your heart's content!" That was Linus Torvalds on Christmas Eve last year. "Listen to the cheerful grinding of your hard disk as you reboot into an all-new kernel—and I'm sure that if your computer could smile, it would have a big silly grin on its non-existent face. So as you sit there in your basement, give your computer the holiday cheer too."

Among the prime highlights of this release is obviously the ext4 filesystem being tagged stable. The backwards-compatible replacement of ext3 introduces bigger filesystems and file sizes, extents, delayed allocation, multi-block allocation, improved block allocation algorithms, faster *fsck*, online defragmentation, and faster and more robust journaling. Along with this release debuts something called, "Graphic Execution Manager" (GPM), a memory manager for the GPU memory. The GPM works as a central manager for buffer object placement, caching, mapping and synchronising.

Other features offered by the new kernel include support for Ultra Wide Band (UWB), wireless USB and UWB-IP; memory management scalability improvements; and container freezer, a group subsystem that utilises the *swsusp* freezer to freeze and restart an arbitrary group of tasks determined by the user. Then there is a boot tracer to help developers optimise boot times; disk shock protection; along with the inclusion of the staging branch that contains incomplete or unstable drivers. For details of all the features, refer to kernelnewbies.org/Linux_2_6_28. Note that an update to the new kernel version has been made available with a wide range of bug fixes on January 18. Linux 2.6.28.1 is available for download from www.kernel.org

Amarok upgrades to 2.0.1.1 with some handy features

Amarok 2.0.1.1 was released on January 11. This release brings back some of the features a lot of us have been waiting for, and which were absent in v2.0. Those of you who were used to the queuing, playlist search and filtering, as well as 'stop after current track' features from the Amarok 1.4 series, and were griping because of their absence when v2.0 came out, have no reason to make a face any more—these features are back again. In addition, the long-awaited sorting of the collection based on the composer has also been introduced in this release.

The developers have also "...extended the Scriptable Service API to allow smoother integration of service scripts. The LibriVox service script has received some love and comes with new icons amongst other improvements. Media device handling has also seen many improvements: MTP devices can now delete multiple tracks at once, and the status bar gives visual feedback when deleting tracks from iPods." Of



course, many of the annoying bugs that were identified in the previous release have also been quashed, like "...the collection scanner now doesn't miss entries anymore and completes its work, and the user now gets a warning when the scanning fails." Download the latest release from amarok.kde.org



Real-Time Messaging Protocol to be opened up

Adobe has announced plans to publish the Real-Time Messaging Protocol (RTMP) specification, which is designed for high-performance transmission of audio, video, and data between Adobe Flash Platform technologies. Providing developers and companies open and free access to RTMP is the latest advancement of the Open Screen Project. This is an industry-wide initiative to enable the delivery of rich multi-screen experiences built on a consistent runtime environment for Web browsing and standalone applications across PCs, mobile devices, and consumer electronics.

RTMP provides an enhanced and efficient way to deliver rich content. Developers and companies will have free and open access to the documented RTMP specification to help enable unparalleled delivery of video, audio and data in the open AMF, SWF, FLV and F4V formats compatible with Adobe Flash Player. The RTMP specification is expected to be posted on the Adobe Developer Connection [www.adobe.com/devnet/rtmp] in the first half of 2009.

Sidux 2008-04, based on Debian Sid as of 2008-12-22

Although the release date of Debian Lenny is still uncertain, there's good news for its users. The Sidux developers have released version 2008-04—a full-featured Debian Sid-based live CD with a special focus on hard disk installations, a clean upgrade path within Sid and additional hardware and software support, enriched and stabilised with Sidux' own packages and scripts. The specific package versions for this release include: Linux 2.6.27.10 (smp, hard preemption), X.org 7.3, KDE 3.5.10, support for newer Intel chipsets (P4x, G4x and Q4x), OpenJDK 6, KVM support, etc. Visit sidux.com/Article303.html to download the ISO.